I really really dont like starterpack memes. I used to like them a lot, and even crafted some of my own.. But starterpack memes are vastly popular, and seems to me to be the main normie template for memes right now. They're so popular that starterpack memepages now frequently function as advertisers for various products or businesses through their memes. In Denmark there have been multiple interviews with various meme makers in this scene, some which I will reference in this piece, and there's even opening an exhibition on digital humor, which includes some of these starterpack memes, making them a part of our cultural heritage. If I'm honest I think the primary reason why I don't like them is due to their popularity because I'm a snob. But this hater attitude also led me to engage critically with the format, in ways I hope to illuminate in this essay, explaining why I hate them from an intellectual, and dare I say, societal perspective.



(@cand.merc.memes. "How did you know we're having a loveparty in Georgia?")

Some short thoughts about when and why a meme works is due. Memes are mostly effectful and funny when the viewer understands the joke, meaning that you have to be familiar with the given phenomena the meme is referencing. I remember when I was exposed to my first memes, like rage comics and so on, the sentiment was always that a good meme was relatable - it made you think "oh i do that". This creates a nice feeling of being seen, and being in on the joke. Memes are thus connected to your social identity, because it requires a certain knowledge about various referential spheres, that allows the viewer to understand the format or content of a given meme. Starter pack memes operate no differently, demanding that the viewer can create a wholeness, and recognize a given person, social group or event out of the bricolage of cultural artifacts. My problem with starterpack memes, is that their formation of meaning is heavily dependent on commodities, and their potential for describing constructed social groups. A 2018 study that sampled 500 starter pack memes found that over 71% of them relied on consumer signals to convey their meaning, while this number rose 86% in memes expressing concepts about political views, and 95% in memes about socio-economic groups. I find this inherent commodified nature of starterpack memes difficult, an opinion materializing in three critiques.

1. **Starterpack memes renders all social life as consumption**



(@memaeladen. “You and your friend planned an interrail that ends in a destination no one has heard about before”. The meme includes statements as “We might stop in Tyrol on the way down”, “When i was on exchange in Paris”.)

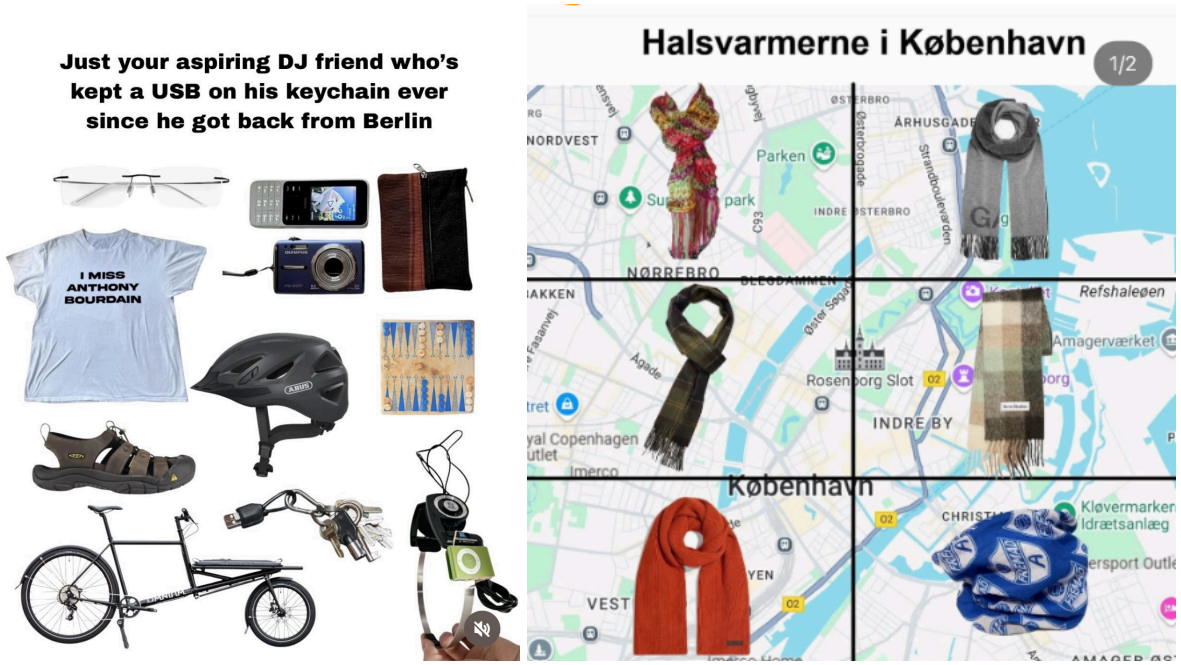
As said most starterpack memes rely on commodities for their meaning. Looking at starterpack memes, you don't see the person or social group that the meme claims to be representing, only the consumer products and practices that these subjects are stereotypically linked with. This has a double effect: When characterizing social life as consumption the very commodity acquires meaning, that has the power to describe the human subject, thus erasing the subjectivity of the person, that now only can acquire meaning through the objects that they consume. This process of turning subjects to passive objects, and commodity objects into active subjects is called reification in marxist thought, and was originally coined by Georg Lukács, and later popularized through the critique of Lukács by Theodor Adorno. In the *Dialectic of Enlightenment* that Adorno wrote with Max Horkheimer, they argue that all reification is forgetting, meaning that reification erases the human labour and meaning attributed to objects, making the living process behind a commodity disappear, and the product now arriving only to us a established fact to be passively consumed.

This is highly true for starterpack memes, where we’re never introduced to the ways in which various commodities gain meaning (how a specific pair of glasses relates to a person going on interrail), but only to facts about a person being defined by the commodities they consume (a person who’s going on interrail would wear these glasses) - the products thus describes the social life of a person and not the other way around. This reification process happens not only to consumer products in starterpack memes. Also statements such as the exchange in Paris, or the possible stop in Tyrol, are commodified and presented as a fact about a given person. The reification process in starterpack memes starts cannibalizing even on memories and future plans.
I find the following passage from Jean Baudrillards *The Consumer Society* fitting:

“The 'person' as absolute value, with its indestructible features and specific force, forged by the whole of the Western tradition as the organizing myth of the Subject - the person with its passions, its will, its character (or banality) - is absent, dead, swept out of our functional universe”.

Starterpack memes has a way of erasing actual social life, the living only arriving to us through the vague meaning of commodities

2. **Starterpack memes naturalize constructed social groups, and act as a false representation of reality**



(@memequeenshq & @cand.merc.meme)

A thing I personally find repulsive about starterpack memes, which might come down to my humanities education, is that it's basically about putting people in boxes, the soulless task of statistics and allocation of individuals to groups, intrinsically linked to police work and the social sciences. I plainly find it reductive of humans and life itself to create these exaggerations. People will often argue that these kinds of representations have value because of their truthlikeness - that people in Nørrebro wear Arc’etryx, that people from Jutland have no taste, and that the guy that lived in Berlin has a digital camera. The argument is that these memes work as a sort of satire of contemporary society, because they accurately represent social groups, archetypes or persons through their consumer products and commodified behavior. As stated I take offence with the consumption aspect of the memes, but even more I oppose that they represent anything “real” in society.

I don't believe that there exist any guy as particular and specific as the one portrayed in the Berlin meme above, but the meme works, because we can recognize a certain “archetype” of person, through the radical exaggeration of a social groups consumer products. Recently Danish politician Inger Støjberg proposed to ban puffer jackets from youth education campuses, because these to her act as a symbol of dominance. Anyone familiar with Danish politics will know Støjberg is an extreme racist and islamophobe, and that the proposal relies on her experience that puffer jackets represent the consumer behavior of muslim men and

boys. This is the same dynamic that drives starterpack memes, that an exaggeration of a social group's consumption is representative of that group's behavior and attitude, because a part of them engages in that sort of consumption. Walter Benjamin was critical towards the concept of representation, because it claims wholeness, even though it's an approximation of fragmented perceptions of life. He called this aestheticization, when shattered experiences of life were totalized, and presented as aestheticized knowledge. Both Støjberg and starterpack memes play into this, by defining social groups through their commodities, and naturalizing this through the constant reproduction of their representations.

In *Simulacra and Simulation* Jean Baudrillard argue that the distinction between reality and representation has broken down. In a famous sentence from the introduction he writes:

"Today abstraction is no longer that of the map, the double, the mirror, or the concept. Simulation is no longer that of a territory, a referential being, or a substance. It is the generation by models of a real without origin or reality: a hyperreal".

He argues that signs used to stand in for something real, but now only refers to other signs - the *hyperreal* being a condition where the sign or model precedes and generates reality. Reading Soundvenue's interview with dansh starterpack meme-maker Memaeladen, this relationship between reality and representation of reality is highly present. In the article owner of the page Andreas tells an anecdote from earlier in the day where he biked through Folkets Park in Copenhagen, which is a popular place to hang out for young people:

"...Andreas had also been there earlier that day and thought to himself that he was now the kind of person who cycled past Spidsroden (a health-food shop and café, ed.) on a sunny day to see if he might run into someone he knew. "Then I spotted a friend and just skid my bike all the way across the asphalt towards her. We both thought it was hilarious — that's obviously a Memaelade meme."

Randomly meeting his friend in the park doesn't create the meme, the meme creates the situation. By biking past Spidsroden Andreas now becomes part of the meme he himself creates, he is now one of those exaggerations portrayed as a representation of reality. The starterpack meme, the hyperreal, precedes actual reality. In the book Baudrillard presents his four successive stages of the image: first stage is reflecting reality, second stage is masking reality, third stage is masking the *absence* of reality, and finally the image bears no relation to reality at all. Saying that starter pack memes bears no relation to reality at all might be a stretch, but I argue that the memes present as a stage one reflection of reality, while actually being stage three - they're masking the absence of reality represented in the image. The article ends with the journalist and the meme-maker posing for a streetstyle photo:

"..."Shortly afterwards, we pose shoulder to shoulder with the afternoon sun in our eyes, both of us struggling not to crack up at the situation. A sunset photoshoot of two men in gorpcore jackets on Elmegade. While hunting for the next Memaelade meme, we have unmistakably become one ourselves."

Again the model creates reality, rather than the other way around, the origin to the situation being a representation online. It seems starter pack memes doesn't describe an existing

situation or social type, rather it's a representational model that people then recognise themselves or others in. Through the constant reproduction of social groups through exaggerated representation of their consumer signals and behavior, starterpack memes naturalizes constructed groups which have no origin in reality, only in the hyperreal.

3. **Starterpack memes claim to represent distinct social groups or behaviours, but often convey meaning through extremely common and widespread signifiers, thus defeating the very purpose of the meme.**



@memequeenshq. "Taking the day off so i can vote and then indulge myself in 12 hours of nonstop flow-tv)

Take a look at the meme above. Which commodities are used to represent the behavior and attitude of this memes subject (a voter that has the day off for whatever reason). We see a cup of coffee, popcorn, a clock, the social media X, the Danish 24 news channel TV2 News etc.- what meaning does these commodities hold? Finally in the bottom right corner, a text notification from the Danish government with a reminder to vote, which 4.784.749 out of the country's 6.031.699 inhabitants received.

In *The Consumer Society* Jean Baudrillard describes a common feature of contemporary marketing as "personalization, or smallest marginal difference" - consumer society sells personalization through objects while actually creating a highly uniform society by producing and promoting commodities with minimal variation. Exactly the same tendency is portrayed in starterpack memes as portrayed above. The very ethos of starterpack memes is the apparent truthlike portrayal of *distinct* social group, but the signifiers of the given social group is often so basic and widespread, given the innate need for being recognizable, that the meme ends up even emptier than before. When a group (voters) is so loosely defined that the commodities that represent it best is coffee and the news (or a euro note denoting the friends going on interrail if we remember back to an earlier meme), what sense is there in

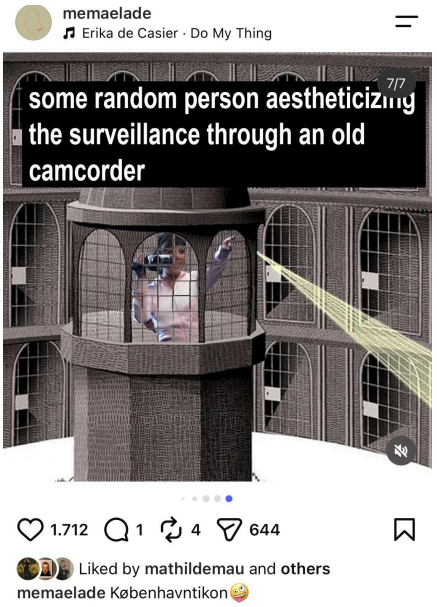
trying to define people through commodities? Could it be that social life is more than consumption?



(It took me 5 minutes to find these AT MOST)

There's a certain tension between virality and distinction in a lot of starterpack memes, which to me highlights the capitalist nature of this form of expression. This also explains why half the starter pack memes you see are ads, because they, as much as ads, only gain meaning through the commodification of life. Now you can make a living as a digital creator, making ads that poses as memes, which means you need to make memes that a lot of people can recognize themselves in, thus making the memes shareable, for your page to grow in order to make it attractive to companies, and in the end sustaining your livelihood. This explains the coffee cup in the above meme.

Conclusion: The populist paradox of starterpack memes



(Caption reads “Copenhagenticon”)

I have no illusions that starterpack memes are nothing more than a mirror to our late capitalist society, and that the world has been arranged around commodities as cultural and social signs, long before this format ever existed. I know that statements and objects function as identity markers that have various amounts of cultural capital, and that the memes in a sense just portray everyday life. My problem with these meme pages in general, is that not only are they reflective and reproducing of consumer society, but often claim to satirize or criticize this. Look at the above meme. While not being a classic starterpack meme, it is that lane, by a creator covered in this piece. It seems to me confusing to critique aestheticizing of our surveillance society, while running a page that is aestheticizing our surveillance society. In the Soundvenue article about Memaeladen he claims to “skewer” niche trends through his memes, but simultaneously he creates a reality where these niche trends matter. Pages like @cand.merc.memes claim to “satirize the LinkedIn segment”, and @realhousewifesofclapton often depict the dread and meaninglessness of modern life in offices. In reality, they often aesthetize modern life, reproduce the capitalist logic that created this modern life, and define social life as ultimately a question about the commodities consumed. Why depict the absurdity of contemporary society on the same terms as those that claim its greatness? This contradiction is what i think is a sort of populist paradox. The memes claim to represent the people against some sort of elite (or at least to make fun of the elite), while doing it through the terms and mechanisms created by, and ultimately benifitting, capitalist society - it’s Trumpian!

All this text and I still haven’t mentioned the idea of “performativity” so prevalent in a lot of these memes once….. that’s for another post.